

# MacOS

MacOS is reasonably private out of the box but has several high-impact settings that are off or misconfigured by default. Check off each setting as you complete it.

Reviewed: June 2026

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# CRITICAL

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## Enable FileVault full-disk encryption

CRITICAL

System Settings → Privacy & Security → FileVault

**Why it matters:** FileVault encrypts your entire drive. Without it, anyone with physical access to your Mac - including law enforcement with a warrant - can extract your files by booting from an external drive, bypassing your login password entirely.

### Steps:

1. Open **System Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → scroll to **FileVault** → click **Turn On**
2. Choose to create a local recovery key - do NOT use your iCloud account as the only recovery option
3. Save the recovery key in your password manager and somewhere physically secure (not on the computer itself)
4. Restart your Mac - encryption runs in the background and may take an hour or more on first run

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## Enable automatic software updates

CRITICAL

System Settings → General → Software Update → Automatic Updates

**Why it matters:** Software updates patch known security vulnerabilities. Attackers actively exploit unpatched systems - running an outdated OS is one of the most common entry points for malware and intrusion.

### Steps:

1. Open **System Settings** → **General** → **Software Update**
2. Click the info icon next to **Automatic Updates** and enable all options: Check for updates, Download, Install macOS updates, Install app updates, and Install security responses
3. Restart your Mac daily to ensure updates are applied promptly

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## Enable Firewall

CRITICAL

System Settings → Network → Firewall

**Why it matters:** macOS's built-in firewall blocks unsolicited incoming network connections. It's off by default - a strange choice - but takes one click to enable. Particularly important on public Wi-Fi.

### Steps:

1. Go to **System Settings** → **Network** → **Firewall**
  2. Toggle **Firewall** on
  3. Click **Options** and enable **Enable stealth mode** - this prevents your Mac from responding to network probe requests
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## Audit app permissions (camera, mic, location)

CRITICAL

System Settings → Privacy & Security

**Why it matters:** macOS apps request access to your camera, microphone, location, contacts, and calendar. Many accumulate permissions over time that they no longer need. Auditing these periodically removes unnecessary access.

### Steps:

1. Open **System Settings** → **Privacy & Security**
  2. Work through each category: **Location Services**, **Microphone**, **Camera**, **Contacts**, **Calendars**
  3. Remove access for any app that doesn't have a clear reason to need it. When in doubt, revoke and see if anything breaks
  4. Under **Location Services** → **System Services**, disable **Location-Based Suggestions** and **Significant Locations**
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## HIGH

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### Disable Siri & Spotlight data sharing

HIGH

System Settings → Siri & Spotlight

**Why it matters:** Siri sends your queries and Spotlight search terms to Apple servers by default to improve suggestions. This includes things you type into Spotlight - file names, app names, search terms - which can reveal a lot about your activity and habits.

#### Steps:

1. Open **System Settings** → **Siri & Spotlight**
2. Toggle off **Ask Siri** if you don't use it
3. Under **Siri Suggestions**, disable **Suggestions in Search**, **Suggestions in Look Up**, and **Suggestions on Lock Screen**
4. Open **System Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → **Analytics & Improvements** and uncheck **Improve Siri & Dictation** and **Share Mac Analytics**

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### Disable advertising identifier & personalized ads

HIGH

System Settings → Privacy & Security → Apple Advertising

**Why it matters:** Apple assigns your Mac an advertising identifier used to target ads across Apple's platforms. Disabling personalized ads limits how Apple and third-party developers can use your activity data for ad targeting.

#### Steps:

1. Open **System Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → **Apple Advertising**
2. Toggle off **Personalized Ads**

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### Lock screen - require password immediately

HIGH

System Settings → Lock Screen

**Why it matters:** A Mac that doesn't require a password after sleep is physically unprotected. Anyone who walks up to your laptop when the screen wakes has full access to everything on it.

#### Steps:

1. Open **System Settings** → **Lock Screen**
  2. Set **Require password after screen saver begins or display is turned off** to **Immediately**
  3. Set **Start screen saver when inactive** to 5 minutes or less
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## MEDIUM

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### Install antivirus / threat protection

MEDIUM

Third-party app - see recommendations

**Why it matters:** macOS has built-in malware protection (XProtect, Gatekeeper) that handles the most common threats. For most users this is sufficient. If you download files from unofficial sources, an antivirus adds an extra layer.

#### Steps:

1. **Malwarebytes** - free version scans on demand, paid version adds real-time protection
2. **Bitdefender** - strong detection rates, lightweight performance impact
3. **NordVPN Threat Protection Pro** - blocks malicious URLs and ads in addition to malware scanning

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### Disable sharing services you don't use

MEDIUM

System Settings → General → Sharing

**Why it matters:** macOS enables several network sharing services that expose your Mac to local network discovery. Unless you actively use them, they represent unnecessary attack surface - especially on public or shared networks.

#### Steps:

1. Go to **System Settings** → **General** → **Sharing**
2. Turn off everything you don't actively use: **File Sharing**, **Screen Sharing**, **Remote Login**, **Remote Management**, **Bluetooth Sharing**
3. Check your computer name at the top - avoid using your real name in it

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## ADVANCED

### Encrypt individual folders

HIGH

Third-party app - see recommendations

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